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9. Goals

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9. Goals

I'm firmly convinced that the goals we set for ourselves account for one of the most crucial factors of all in helping us to experience happiness. Goals bring life into focus. They give meaning and purpose to life. But they must all be grounded in God's plans and purposes.

Climbing Mt. Whitney

I have a friend who was determined to climb Mt. Whitney, the tallest mountain in the continental United States—more than 14,000 feet high. He invited me to go along. It is a long, hard, two-day climb. Each person has to carry a heavy backpack with two days of food, extra clothing in case it rains or snows, a sleeping bag, and a tank of oxygen.

The day came when we stood at the foot of the trail, thrilled as we looked up and saw the peak high up in the sky. We had many trails ahead of us. There were long, easy sections. There were fast-moving mountain streams. There were long, steep climbs that left our muscles aching and our lungs panting for breath.

Toward the end of the first day, the shrubbery and grass began to disappear and we left the tall trees behind. There were rocks and some small, gnarled, tough, little trees. As we looked up, the peak seemed as far away as ever.

We stopped for the night and removed our packs from our weary backs. There was a cold, biting wind blowing. We built a fire, heated up some soup, and sat back to enjoy the breath-taking scenery. We didn't mind the aching muscles. We accepted the pain and the cold as a part of reaching our goal.

Finally, we rolled out our sleeping bags, crawled in, and tried to sleep on the hard rocks with a howling wind blowing that made us huddle as far down as possible in our sleeping bags.

In the morning, when we crawled out of our bags, our bones ached from spending the night on that hard rock, and our muscles ached from yesterday's climb, but we were happy and wouldn't have wanted it any other way. After a breakfast of dried meat and peanuts, we hoisted our packs up on our aching backs and started out.

The trail became steeper and steeper. Many times, at the foot of a long, steep climb, it looked like we had finally reached the peak. But when we reached the top, we discovered that there were more peaks beyond. We climbed down, up, down, up. The air became very thin, and we had to breathe oxygen from our little tank in order to keep going.

Those little peaks seemed to keep coming forever.

Continuing to climb those lesser peaks made sense only because we kept that final peak in view. Finally, after climbing for two days, sometimes through deep snow banks, and seemingly having expended every ounce of energy, we stood on the peak—14,000 feet up—with a breathtaking, 360 degree view to enjoy.

Our goal of reaching the peak gave meaning to subjecting ourselves to the expenditure of energy, pain, sleeping on hard rock, eating dried food, and lugging a heavy pack on our backs. It was an exhilarating, rewarding experience!

Our Life-Long Goal

The Bible says,

For we must all stand before Christ to be judged. We will each receive whatever we deserve for the good or evil we have done in this earthly body. —2 Corinthians 5:10

Each individual, no matter who we are, will see Jesus and give an account of what he or she has done. God has given us instructions for living, and we will be evaluated on the basis of them. We do well to prepare for that day.

A few years ago, I received an official-looking envelope in the mail. It was from the United States Government, asking me to appear before the Internal Revenue Service to give an account of what I had done with my money for the three previous years.

There was nothing to fear, because I had retained the services of an excellent CPA who had guided me in properly accounting for the use of my money and paying taxes as necessary. After a very thorough review, the IRS announced that we had made some errors and were entitled to a \$500 refund.

So it will be when we stand before the judgment seat of Christ. There will be nothing to fear if we have managed our lives as he instructed us. Be assured that we will be judged according to his Word.

When Moses died, it is recorded that God gave Joshua specific instructions as he took over the leadership of the Israelites:

Be strong and very courageous. Be careful to obey all the instructions Moses gave you. Do not deviate from them, turning either to the right or to the left. Then you will be successful in everything you do. —Joshua 1:7

King Solomon, who tried everything under the sun, came to the following conclusion:

Fear God and obey his commands, for this is everyone's duty. God will judge us for everything we do, including every secret thing, whether good or bad. —Ecclesiastes 12:13-14

In his first letter to Timothy, the apostle Paul advised:

Work hard so you can present yourself to God and receive his approval. Be a good worker, one who does not need to be ashamed and who correctly explains the word of truth. —2 Timothy 2:15

In order to live a life pleasing to God, we must know and obey his Word. Not only will this allow us to receive his approval at the end of our lives, it will bring us a life of happiness and blessing. God's Word keeps us from stumbling, gives us insight and understanding of righteousness, and makes our way prosperous as we follow him. I have found the best way for me to do this is to daily follow the apostle Paul's instruction:

Set your mind on things above, not on earthly things. For ... your life is now hidden with Christ in God. —Colossians 3:2-3, NIV

This overarching, life-long goal will guide us in experiencing a life of happiness and contentment.

A Focus on the Wrong Goals Will Lead to Frustration

We tend to get involved with people, activities, and our possessions with a great surge of energy and pleasurable expectation. Beginning a new relationship, landing a new job, having money to purchase a desired material blessing. Anticipation fans our expectations. Our hope is that reaching our goal will result in great satisfaction and pleasure. Then, after several months or years of effort, we end up disillusioned.

There are people who have made plenty of money but have no good reason for spending it. Shopping malls are full of people aimlessly wandering from store to store, not looking for anything in particular, often buying something they don't need.

There are those individuals who have developed their talent and ability and now have no desire to use it. They have learned a trade or a profession, but receive no satisfaction from their work, even though they are using their talent and the pay is good.

Some people can't wait to retire so they can pursue a life of leisure. However, I've met many retirees who are hopelessly bored with luxury and ease.

Many beautiful, healthy, affectionate people are tremendously unhappy. Their marriage has turned to ashes. They feel as though the demands of the relationship are too great, so either the husband or wife lashes out at the other or just walks away and abandons the whole thing. Couples are abandoning marriage and their families by the droves.

What these people have discovered is that good goals don't satisfy. Here are some goals that should have satisfied, but didn't:

1. Making money
2. Acquiring things
3. Building a business or career
4. Retirement
5. Using talent and ability
6. Marriage
7. Parenthood

These are all good goals. Everyone must make a living and provide for their future. We all need to do what is necessary to use our talents and abilities. Who would argue with having a good marriage and a happy family life as a goal? Surely everyone who has worked hard is entitled to retirement.

And yet, after years of sincere effort pursuing good goals many people still end up tremendously unhappy. I am reminded of what King Solomon discovered:

I have seen all the things that are done under the sun; all of them are meaningless, a chasing after the wind. —Ecclesiastes 1:14, NIV

And I saw that all toil and all achievement spring from one person's envy of another. This too is meaningless, a chasing after the wind. —Ecclesiastes 4:4, NIV

His gloomy conclusions have a strangely modern ring to them. I hear almost the same words from my clients:

“I’m fed up with competing.”

“I’m frustrated after all these years of hard work.”

“I’ve poured my life into this family and nobody cares.”

Doing good things all your life is like climbing a steep section of a mountain trail. You are only willing to endure aching muscles when you keep the peak in mind. Doing good things only has meaning and purpose if in the doing of them you keep the real long-range goal in mind. Only if your behavior, your conversation, your feelings and emotions, your choices, and your goals are pleasing in God’s eyes, will your day-by-day activities and responsibilities have meaning and purpose.

The Bible provides us with these principles for helping us set our goals:

You must love the Lord your God with all your heart, all your soul, and all your mind. This is the first and greatest commandment. A second is equally important: Love your neighbor as yourself. —Matthew 22:37-39

Perspective

The day of the Lord will come as unexpectedly as a thief. Then the heavens will pass away with a terrible noise, and the very elements themselves will disappear in fire, and the earth and everything on it will be found to deserve judgment. —2 Peter 3:10

I was reading this verse one time while preparing for an overseas trip. At the time, I was a partner in a chain of eight large restaurants. I visited them all before leaving, which was a long, tiring chore.

The thought occurred to me then that it doesn't make sense to put your heart and soul into something that eventually will be destroyed. I could picture all eight of those restaurants burning to the ground. No wonder riches don't satisfy; they are only temporary. We all sense, at least vaguely, that earthly blessings won't last forever.

A few years ago, I was a partner in an apartment house project. We were in the process of constructing a new building and had the roof on and the doors and windows installed in a three-story structure containing twelve apartment units. Before we could complete any more work, a strong wind blew down the entire building. As I studied the wreckage, it was as though an audible voice was telling me not to put my hopes in buildings. They are just a puff of wind ... or an earth tremor ... or a touch of fire ... away from being destroyed.

Why should things like this happen? We can't really answer that question. However, the very fact that it does happen may be why Jesus said:

Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moths and vermin destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moths and vermin do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also. —Matthew 6:19-21

Granted, everyone must make a living. In the process, we often acquire a home and possessions. If we follow the laws of economics carefully, we can acquire great wealth in the same amount of time that someone else barely ekes out a living. The futility of it is not in the possession of wealth; it's putting our whole heart and soul into something that will eventually be destroyed.

What, then, is important? The Bible tells us:

Since everything will be destroyed in this way, what kind of people ought you to be? You ought to live holy and godly lives —2 Peter 3:11, NIV

Everyone must live out life every day in a godly way. How should we conduct ourselves in the process? Here are some Bible verses that can help us:

Seek the Kingdom of God above all else, and live righteously, and he will give you everything you need. —Matthew 6:33

Let's stop condemning each other. Decide instead to live in such a way that you will not cause another believer to stumble and fall. —Romans 14:13

For the Kingdom of God is not a matter of what we eat or drink, but of living a life of goodness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit. If you serve Christ with this attitude, you will please God, and others will approve of you, too. So then, let us aim for harmony in the church and try to build each other up. —Romans 14:17-19

The LORD has told you what is good, and this is what he requires of you: to do what is right, to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God. —Micah 6:8

Who may climb the mountain of the LORD? Who may stand in his holy place? Only those whose hands and hearts are pure, who do not worship idols and never tell lies. They will receive the LORD's blessing and have a right relationship with God their savior. —Psalm 24:3-5

You get no credit for being patient if you are beaten for doing wrong. But if you suffer for doing good and endure it patiently, God is pleased with you. For God called you to do good, even if it means suffering, just as Christ suffered for you. He is your example, and you must follow in his steps. He never sinned, nor ever deceived anyone. He did not retaliate when he was insulted, nor threaten revenge when he suffered. He left his case in the hands of God, who always judges fairly. —1 Peter 2:20-23

Guard your heart above all else, for it determines the course of your life. —Proverbs 4:23

*Create in me a pure heart, O God, and renew a steadfast spirit within me.
—Psalm 51:10, NIV*

When we set our earthly goals with God's principles guiding us, we will be able to maintain our perspective of our life-long goal of living for him.

Trusting God

Most of us experience happiness when all is peaceful in our marriage and with our family and friends, when we can make our mortgage payments, when there are no conflicts within our family, and when we have enough money to pay our bills. Our happiness is taken away from us when we experience disagreements with our marriage partner, trouble with our children, illness, death, financial struggles, or problems with our employment.

Our happiness does not depend upon our earthly circumstances.

However, if our happiness is dependent upon situations in our lives turning out right, we will soon be disappointed. Our happiness does not depend upon our earthly circumstances.

God wants us to entrust the people and events of our lives into his hands. We can do everything in our power to make things come out "right," and yet there are many aspects of our lives that we cannot control. God is in control of all things. We must take a step of faith and trust in his plans and purposes for our lives.

The Bible provides us with encouragement for this journey.

Trust in the LORD with all your heart; do not depend on your own understanding. Seek his will in all you do, and he will show you which path to take. —Proverbs 3:5-6

And the LORD will continually guide you, and satisfy your desire in scorched places, and give strength to your bones; and you will be like a watered garden, and like a spring of water whose waters do not fail. —Isaiah 58:11, NASB

Don't worry about anything; instead, pray about everything. Tell God what you need, and thank him for all he has done. Then you will experience God's peace, which exceeds anything we can understand. His peace will guard your hearts

and minds as you live in Christ Jesus. —Philippians 4:6-7

I have learned how to be content with whatever I have. I know how to live on almost nothing or with everything. I have learned the secret of living in every situation, whether it is with a full stomach or empty, with plenty or little. For I can do everything through Christ, who gives me strength. —Philippians 4:11-13

O LORD, I have come to you for protection; don't let me be disgraced. Save me, for you do what is right. Turn your ear to listen to me; rescue me quickly. Be my rock of protection, a fortress where I will be safe. —Psalm 31:1-2

I trust in God, so why should I be afraid? —Psalm 56:11

Give your burdens to the Lord, and he will take care of you. —Psalm 55:22

Life doesn't always make sense. I recently spoke with a young woman, age thirty-two, who lost her eyesight at age sixteen. Another woman in her early 40s, seriously crippled with rheumatoid arthritis, told me of her husband walking out on her. My friend's twenty-four-year-old son died unexpectedly. Another good friend lost a daughter in a car collision. Yesterday, I heard about another friend, in his early 50s, who had a massive heart attack and died. I'm constantly hearing about crisis experiences that parents are having with their children. This is the stuff of life.

I have a long list of questions to ask Jesus when I see him; I'm sure you do too. In the meantime, we need to trust him.

And we need to develop that trust day-by-day. We need to trust God when life is good. We need to commit our days and our circumstances and our loved one into his hands. We need to trust him when we are happy and when life is peaceful, so that when a crisis comes, and we can be sure it will, we will have a trust that is sure.

Jesus said,

I have told you all this so that you may have peace in me. Here on earth you will have many trials and sorrows. But take heart, because I have overcome the world. —John 16:33

The apostle Peter wrote,

Finally, all of you should be of one mind. Sympathize with each other. Love each other as brothers and sisters. Be tenderhearted, and keep a humble attitude. Don't repay evil for evil. Don't retaliate with insults when people insult you. Instead, pay them back with a blessing. That is what God has called you to do, and he will grant you his blessing.
—1 Peter 3:8-9

When we use God's Word to help us set our goals, our lives have meaning and purpose, and we will experience the happiness and contentment we are longing for.

Questions for Reflection/Discussion:

1. In what ways do the goals you are presently pursuing incorporate the principle of a life lived for God?
2. What goals do you currently have that are focused on earthly accomplishments only?
3. What steps do you need to take in order to trust God more with every aspect of your life?

Memorize: Colossians 3:2-3

Set your mind on things above, not on earthly things. For ... your life is now hidden with Christ in God.

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We're grateful you've taken this step in your spiritual journey. Your growth in Christ encourages us, and we pray this has been a blessing—strengthening your faith, deepening your understanding of God's Word, and equipping you to live for His glory.

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Thank you again for partnering with us in the Great Commission. May the Lord continue to fill you with joy, peace, and purpose as you walk with Him.

In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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